SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #22 · MEDIA AND SOCIAL MEDIA

“If I'm not liked online, I don't matter.”

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Where it often comes from

Likes, followers, shares, and comments feel like measures of worth, and they trigger the brain’s reward systems. Young people especially can tie self-esteem to numbers. A post with few responses can feel like rejection, and silence can feel like being forgotten.

What Scripture teaches

Paul asks, “Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God?” Proverbs says, “The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high.” The psalmist says, “I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made,” and God declares, “The LORD your God is among you… He will rejoice over you with gladness.” God told Samuel, “Man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.” Our worth was set at creation and sealed at the cross, and no number of likes can raise or lower it.

> *“Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ”* (Galatians 1:10).

Also see

> “The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high” (Proverbs 29:25).

> “For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother’s womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well” (Psalm 139:13–14).

> “The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing” (Zephaniah 3:17).

> “But the LORD said to Samuel, ‘Do not consider his appearance or height, for I have rejected him; the LORD does not see as man does. For man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.’” (1 Samuel 16:7).

Common self-statements

- No likes means no one cares.
- My worth is my follower count.
- If it flops, I flopped.
- I have to post to be seen.
- People who matter get attention.
- I am invisible without engagement.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling ignored and concluding I do not matter.
- Mind reading: Assuming silence means disapproval.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either popular or worthless.
- Labeling: Measuring myself by a number.

Challenging questions

- What do I hope likes will give me?

- How do I feel when a post gets little response?
- Who in real life values me, regardless of a screen?
- What does God say about my worth?
- What would change if I posted without checking numbers?
- What offline activity could remind me of my value?

Truth summary

> Likes measure attention, not worth. God made me, loves me, and delights in me. I can use social media without letting it decide who I am.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Pride
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Worldly
- Fear
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I'm not liked online, I don't matter"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I'm not liked online, I don't matter." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I hope likes give me?
- ☐ How do I feel when posts flop?
- ☐ Who values me in person?
- ☐ What does God say?
- ☐ What if I did not check numbers?
- ☐ What offline thing helps?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My worth is not a number.
- ☐ I seek God's approval first.
- ☐ The fear of man is a snare.
- ☐ God delights in me.
- ☐ Real people value me.
- ☐ I can post without needing applause.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Galatians 1:10**
  "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."
- ☐ **Psalm 139:13–14**
  "For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- ☐ **Zephaniah 3:17**
  "The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing."

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Worth beyond numbers: Each day, note one person who values you in real life.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Zephaniah 3:17 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord rejoices over me, whatever the numbers say.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Take a break. Go offline for a day or weekend.
- ☐ Hide the counts. Turn off like counts if possible.
- ☐ Invest in people. Spend time face to face with those who love you.
- ☐ Memorize Zephaniah 3:17. Say it when you check the numbers.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I'm not liked online, I don't matter": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Worth beyond numbers
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I'm not liked online, I don't matter.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I have looked to likes for worth. Remind me that You delight in me. Free me from the fear of man, and let me share without needing applause. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.